Notes from Underground

Notes from Underground was written by the Russian novelist, Fyodor Dostoevsky. This is one o the best masterpieces, published in 1864. It was also translated into many languages. The novel's story and thematic strands have led the critics to term it the first existentialist piece in literature. The novel presents the story of an anonymous narrator, who is living in the town of St. Petersburg. The first part is his monologue, while the second comprises the events he has to undergo during his lifetime.

Summary of Notes from Underground

The story is set in the Russian town of St. Petersburg, where the narrator is living a retired life with bitter memories. After having some inheritance, he starts writing his reflections about his life, his environment, his attitude toward modern society, and interpretations and explanations of his actions. The first part of the story "Underground" shows him having crossed forty years. It serves the purpose of an explanatory note regarding his thinking about the world. He starts narrating the events after expressing his disgust about himself, ruminating that his intellectual capacity and his excessive reading have caused this destruction of his mental thinking, taking it as the main reason for the ruination of all intelligent people. Disillusioned with his theories, he appreciates the idea of subline but is unaware of its abstraction.

Slowly, this underground man comes to the point that he hates utilitarianism, thinking that it is not man's primary purpose of living a good life; rather, the main purpose of his life is to use the free will that he thinks is of prime significance. He forms his own opinion about utilitarianism, saying that the actions of doing nasty things are the main expression of the use of this free will. He goes on to think that has started enjoying his pains and developing a capacity to take pleasure even in toothache, headache, or any other such pain. Although he understands his bizarre behavior, he does not take pride in

it; rather he feels disgusted at it, thinking that he is unable to become anything except what he is. With these thoughts, the first part of the narrative comes to an end.

The second part "Apropos of the Wet Snow" starts with the events from the life of the man when he was just 24. He shows how he used to act upon the ideas he used to harbor in his mind to reach the stage of maturity from his romantic idealism to practicality and pragmatism. However, cynicism has prevailed over his thoughts, making him become disenchanted with this loftiness and beauty of his thoughts. This section also sheds light on his interaction with the people he comes across in his life, ranging from soldiers to school fellows and pimps to prostitutes but he soon feels alienated from the public in that he feels himself betrayed. He has come to the conclusion that he cannot act normally with the people, the reason that he considers people worthless and humiliating. This also becomes a source of his self-repudiation and self-loathing.

The demonstration of his self-loathing appears in the shape of disgusting behavior toward others. For example, he is obsessed with the idea of not yielding way to a soldier in the park. Similarly, he visits his schoolmates and goes with them for a dinner but humiliates them openly and yet craves a good relationship with them. When he returns home, he visits the market and stops to rescue Liza after delivering her a moral lecture about life hereafter. However, she also pities him when she visits him later after which he berates her, making her flee his apartment. After ending his notes here, he decides to stop writing and yet continues.

Major Themes in Notes from Underground

1. **Passivity**: The novel shows the thematic strand of passivity through the thoughts of the man. He is engaged in thinking over everything else under the sun with little action on any of these. The reason behind his

passivity is his over-thinking of everything, and doing nothing. Even if he thinks out an idea to take action, he contradicts it after giving it a second thought, refuting his own argument of doing it. For example, when he plans to visit Zverkov to slap him, he arrives too late and never executes his plan, leading to eventual inertia in him. Therefore, the more intelligent he makes out of himself, the more boredom prevails on him, making him more passive and inactive.

2. **Loneliness**: Loneliness is another prevalent theme in the novel in that the underground man not only stays lonely but also keeps his loneliness a prize by keeping himself aloof from society. Living by himself and depending on none has made him not only a cynic but also a rude person. His scorn toward others has brought rejection from them, intensifying his own sense of loneliness. This loneliness and its intensification have made his feelings ambivalent toward society as he shows during his meeting with the officer or with Zverkov. By the end, it becomes so biting and embarrassing for him that he even feels ashamed to have written the notes.
3. **Human Nature**: The reflective introduction of the first part of the novel shows the thematic strand of human nature that similar to him, is spiteful and sick, the reason that he considers human beings incapable of rational thinking. The comparison of human beings with animals and the degeneration of human nature make him brood over his assessment and make him feel more pessimistic and nihilistic, the reason that he considers all the irrational thoughts part of human nature. In fact, his self-hatred reaches its peak by the end when he says that "it's impossible to be as spiteful and stupid as I am."
4. **Rational Thinking**: The main argument of the underground man is that human beings are not rational creatures and that human history is full of irrationality. Even the best interests of man are not served if everybody claims to be so, for if it would be based on scientific thinking, then it is not free will, and if it is free will, it would be irrational. The best example

that he presents is his self-contradiction that he contradicts every other argument that he himself presents. For example, he faces the choice when he thinks about Zverkov whether he should visit him and the same goes when he tries to invite Liza.

5. **Suffering:** The theme of self-loathing is almost similar to the theme of suffering, for the underground man enjoys making him suffer from his self-loathing. He hates himself and hates others. Even in his fantasy, he tries to irritate others while he teases his schoolfellows and whomever he meets in the real world. When he meets Liza, he brings her to tears by degrading her at the situation she was in.
6. **Hatred:** Hatred for others as well as for the person himself is another major theme. Even the opening lines of the notes of the underground man show that he is a self-hater involved in excessive self-loathing. He says that "I am an unattractive man," which points to his excessive self-hatred. Therefore, when he trivializes rationality and free will, he contradicts himself as well as others and comes to the point of self-loathing again. His fantasy about slapping the prostitute and his treatment of his schoolmates are also manifestations of his hatred for others.
7. **Revenge:** The theme of revenge in the novel is significant in that the underground man uses it to justify justice. He does exact revenge from the officer whom he stalks in the early pages when he sees him having a stroll in the park, and he argues the case against his idea of revenge that he would only be satisfied if the officer acknowledges his presence. Later, he tries to exact revenge from Liza and even from Zverkov but decides against it.

Major Characters in Notes from Underground

1. **The Underground Man**: He is a protagonist of the novel, only known as the underground man is anonymous. It has made him an anti-hero because of his unusual introduction of himself that he is a pessimistic

as well as a self-loather. In his thoughts, he is too analytical and sometimes self-contradictory in this analysis but in his actions, he is too passive, boring, and loathsome. His analytic and brooding nature has rendered him socially isolated, the reason that he has become too much cynical and touchy. This also has led him to have low self-opinion about himself and consequently about the entire humanity. His reading, too, has contributed to his cynical and touchy nature, the reason that he even thinks of slapping the prostitutes and then goes late so that he should not do it. Therefore, the major reason for his being bitter about himself and others is his low opinion of himself.

2. **The Officer**: The officer appears in the first part when the underground man tries to pick up a fight with him, even though he does not take a cue from it and ignores the underground man. Yet, his brooding nature forces him to seek revenge from him for which he thinks to ask him for a dual and rejects this notion later. Then he again thinks of bumping into him somewhere in the street so that he could impose his existence on him to accept him. However, when he has almost done it, the officer again either ignores him or pretends to ignore him which further adds to his misery.
3. **Zverkov:** Zverkov appears in the first part and stays with the underground man in his ruminations due to his significance as being his close friend since his school days. His popularity in the romantic exploits has impacted the underground man lesser than his bragging about those exploits. That is why he visits the going-away party thrown by other classmates and humiliates him. Although he later begs his pardon, he is surprised at his impassionate response that he has never realized the insults. Later, he thinks of slapping him when they are going to meet at the house of a prostitute but does not find him there.
4. **Liza:** Liza is one of the significant characters as the underground man considers her worth his visit along with his classmate, Zverkov. Although he talks to her in condescending terms, considering their

loveless life with her curse for both, he suddenly comes to invite her to his home to help her. In both cases, his sudden turn of mind shows that he is sympathetic but feels that she should also sympathize with him, the reason that he breaks down before her when she visits him. She finally leaves him, throwing his money in his face.

5. **Apollon:** As the servant of the underground man, Apollon is rather a snobbish person as demonstrated through his defiance and irritating behavior. Despite his successive efforts to drive him crazy by stopping wages to him, Apollon stares silently and does nothing which makes the underground man crazier. The underground man, therefore, terms him executioner on account of his perseverance to drive him crazy instead of showing his own craziness.
6. **Simonov:** Simonov is the former classmate of the underground man. Whenever the underground man is fed up with life after much brooding over his existence and the world, he visits him when they plan a party for Zverkov, another of their schoolfellow. He thinks that the underground man is not trustworthy, the reason that he does not want to permit him to the party. Despite keeping the underground man in heavy debt, he again lends him money after the underground man begs for it.
7. **Ferfichkin:** Ferfichkin is another of his schoolfellow with whom they attend the party at the apartment of Simonov. He knows the reality of the underground man since his school days and threatens him not to brag about anything. He again fixes him by challenging him to have a dual when the underground man insults Zverkov.
8. **Anton Antonych Setochkin:** The character of Anton is significant in the course of the novel in that he is the main source of lending money to the underground man as being his immediate boss.

Writing Style of Notes from Underground

Dostoevsky presents highly manipulative notes in an existentialist style

despite using a simple narrative technique of the first-person narrative. Even though the text has been translated from Russian into English, still the structural taste of the sentences has not been lost. Most of the sentences are multi-layered with an iteration of the main thematic strand of the novel. For literary devices, the author has relied heavily on metaphors besides similes, irony, and hyperboles.

Analysis of the Literary Devices in Notes from Underground